

LIVING IN THE PRESENT

SPRING NEWSLETTER 2024

Friends, it is with great joy that I write to you as I reflect on this abundantly grace filled spring semester of Via Nova. Saint Gianna Molla articulates one of the prominent themes of my second semester in Via well when she says “As to the past, let us entrust it to God’s mercy, the future to divine Providence. Our task is to live holy in the present moment.” The Lord has invited me to lean into the present moment, revealing the truth that my path to heaven lies in *this* moment in time. I have come to realize that “living holy the present moment” requires surrender, trust and an openness to God's grace.

An obstacle that I can face often in the busyness of my life is resistance. Whether it be because of school, or figuring out my next steps, I can coast through the present moment, waiting for what comes next. When I fall into this way of living I reject what God has for me right now. The present moment is where God dwells with his grace. How often do we reject His grace? I think about how often we can spend time focused on the next thing and planning out our lives. While planning for the future has its place and time, we can become too busy and completely miss what God is trying to reveal to us right now. We make ourselves too busy for God. I have to be intentional about recentering myself to the present moment. Blessed Solanus Casey spoke to this issue well when he stated “We must be faithful to the present moment or we will frustrate the plan of God for our lives.”

I was struck by the words of Blessed Solanus Casey when he said “We must be faithful to the present moment or we will frustrate the plan of God for our lives.” God's grace, his mercy and his love abides in the here and now. In order to submit ourselves to His holy will we have to be receptive to what is in front of us in each moment. When we fail to be intentional in the present moment, we reject what God is inviting us into right now. Whether because of stress or feeling overwhelmed amidst the busyness of my life, I can tend to coast through the present moment. Sometimes this is lived out through distractions while in seminar. I can spend time thinking about all of the tasks I have to get done instead of participating in the conversation and receiving what others have to say. I can become so stressed, consumed by worry about the next task, that I miss what God has for me right now. As I have spent time working through this, I have come to realize that surrender and trust is essential.

In the midst of a full life, we are called to live in the present. For living in the present allows us to be receptive to God's grace and opens our hearts to His plan for our life. This way of life requires constant surrender, trust, and attentiveness to what is in front of us in each moment. God has beautifully tied in the challenges of managing school, Via, and encountering my strengths and weaknesses into learning how to find the balance of entering into the present, discerning the future, and ultimately living out what God is inviting me into each day.



Reading Aristotle's *Nicomachean Ethics* was the beginning of recognizing the value of living intentionally in the present moment. I learned this through Aristotle's practical explanation of how virtue is a means to happiness. Aristotle deems happiness as the highest good of man, and defines happiness as an activity of the soul in accord with virtue. After Aristotle defines happiness, he explores what virtue is. Aristotle begins this by exploring the nature of virtue as it relates to vice. He helps us understand this through thinking about virtue as the middle term between two vices, the excess and deficiency. We can think of the virtue of courage as an example in unpacking this. Courage is the middle term between the excess, recklessness, and the deficiency, cowardice. Aristotle says "It is on account of the pleasure involved that man will do base things, and it is on account of the pain that we abstain from noble ones." Here, Aristotle is pointing out that we fall into vice when we act on what we feel, rather than acting on what is good. We can fall into cowardice when we fear the pain involved in pursuing courage, and we can fall into recklessness when we are motivated by pleasure. Rather than being ruled by what he feels, the courageous man is able to act on account of what is most good. For the courageous man is able to distinguish his actions from his passions. The courageous man acts on

account of the good. And so, Aristotle defines virtue as a means to true happiness.

The necessity of virtue to arrive at happiness is expounded further as Aristotle points out that it is not by one virtuous act that man arrives at happiness, but rather by many. It is not by acting courageously one time that a man is called courageous, but rather by practicing courage habitually. Because of the importance of habitual practice in building a virtue, we can understand that happiness is not something we obtain overnight but rather is cultivated through building virtuous habits throughout a lifetime.

Recognizing the truth that habitual virtue leads man to happiness is essential to understanding the proper pursuit of happiness. Whether christian or pagan, we all desire happiness and Aristotle proves that it is necessary to participate in virtue to ultimately arrive at that end. For the Christian hungry to live the gospel, in particular, this truth was encouraging and motivating. We, as Christians, strive for heaven, desiring to live out the radical call to holiness; the call to participate in the good in every moment to the point that we become like goodness itself, Christ. I find the radical call of the Christian to be quite daunting. I can look to the lives of the saints, read about their radical holiness and see it as unattainable. However, Aristotle reminds us that

arriving at this place does not happen overnight, it happens through habitual participation in the good. For, if we choose to participate in the good that is put before us in the present moment we inch closer to imitating the lives of the saints. After all, it is in choosing what is good again and again that we build good habits and become virtuous people that more closely resemble the saints. Through responding to God's grace and his mercy, we one day will be perfect in holiness and virtuous, in turn allowing us to arrive at that perfect happiness, union with God.

Aristotle's *Ethics* was deeply impactful and ultimately refined my understanding of how to approach journeying through this life for heaven. I deeply love how Aristotle uses observations of the world around us to discover various truths about man. Initially, the *Ethics* was slightly intimidating, but after wrestling with the text for a couple of weeks I found it to bear much fruit. If you have ever desired to read Aristotle I encourage you to give it a try! Allow the Lord to surprise you in your ability to understand and leave with takeaways from your reading.



A snap shot of my neighborhood



All of the fellows at a coffee shop in New Orleans



The courtyard of St. Patrick's Catholic Church taken during our trip to New Orleans



The fellows and Luke, during a seminar on the *Ethics*



A group photo of the the Fellows, Luke and Mel

WORK AND THE FUTURE

While feeling called to begin applying what I was learning through the *Ethics*, I was also invited to begin discerning my next step. During my first semester in Via Nova I worked as a medical assistant at Acadiana OB/GYN with Dr. Cudihy and Dr. Volts. The appointments that I enjoyed assisting with the most were ultrasounds. While these appointments, specifically in obstetrics, can be scary, they are also such a joy. There is nothing like the moment a mother hears her baby's heart beat for the first time. It was such a blessing to experience the gift of new life alongside patients. After chaperoning ultrasound after ultrasound, I began to discern sonography i.e. working as an ultrasound technician. This spring I continue to discern sonography as a career and have begun taking practical steps to move forward in that direction. Since January I have been taking classes at SLCC to work towards finishing my prerequisites to begin a sonography program for the fall of 2025.

The step towards applying to sonography school has opened new doors of discernment and has required proactive steps in figuring out what is next. As exciting and good this new potential path is, it has also been a challenge. The temptation has been to coast through the last month of Via, passively receive what is happening here and give all of my attention to what is next. In these moments of temptation, I'm reminded that while discerning the future is important, it is also important to be present to what is before me. God exists in the now. Through remaining present, the Lord is continuing to prepare and form me for what is to come. I am still in the process of learning how to balance these things and draw myself back to what is in front of me.

PRAYER

In the mornings when I am in prayer I think of the beatitude "Blessed are the poor in spirit for theirs is the kingdom of heaven." Simply put, to be poor in spirit means to recognize that I am a beggar before the Lord who needs him for everything. For I am nothing without God. The Lord has so gracefully revealed how deeply I need him to do anything well. Throughout the day, I am invited to surrender my worries and anxieties to Him. To live holy in the present is impossible without recognizing our complete and total dependence on God's grace. I am slowly discovering the peace of trusting in the Father's loving hands and allowing him to take care of everything.

A prayer that seems to articulate this invitation comes from St. Francis Assisi when he says: "Lord, help me to live this day, quietly, easily. To lean upon Thy great strength, trustfully, restfully. To wait for the unfolding of Thy will, patiently, serenely. To meet others, peacefully, joyously. To face tomorrow, confidently, courageously." I ask of your prayers in these months of discernment that I may rely entirely on God and find peace in knowing that He takes care of me.



St. Patrick's Catholic Church

As I approach the end of this year in Via I continue recognizing the fruits. I have encountered many ups and downs, have discovered new strengths and weaknesses in myself and have begun to learn to surrender and allow God's grace and mercy to flow into all aspects of my life. It has been such a blessing to have so many wonderful people walk with me throughout this year. I give my gratitude to all of my supporters, my donors, my formator, Katherine Greene, my spiritual director, Mrs. Robin Hebert, to the many tutors that have led our seminars, and to Mel Leece and Luke Ungarino. Each of you have been abundantly generous and so supportive, may God bless you in your charity.

I invite you all to strive to live more fully in the present moment. Put away your worries about the past, your anxieties about the future and open your heart to whatever the Lord has for you right now. I encourage you to ask the Lord to reveal himself to you in the present and always let him take care of everything. If you have any personal prayer intentions you wish for me to pray for please let me know!

God Bless,
Ann-Ayrisse Salvatierra



Dr. Michael Foley's presentation at the Via House



Cooking breakfast at the Via House



Praise on the Porch



The Fellows



Seminar with Dr. Cory Hayes



Poetry Night



The Fellows along with some friends after watching *Les Miserables*



The Fellows, Luke, and friends enjoying a meal in New Orleans



Rachel and I